

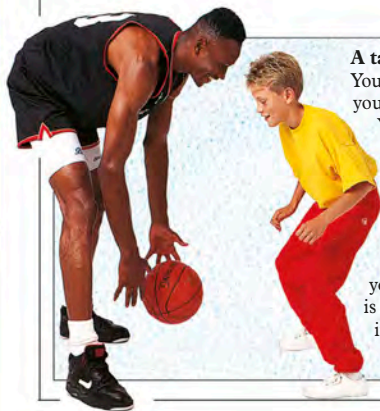


SKELETON

Without a frame to support your body you would collapse, lose your shape, and be unable to move. Your body's frame is called a skeleton. It gives your body strength and it protects the soft parts inside. Your skeleton is made up of more than 200 bones. They are light enough to allow you to move around easily, and they have joints so that you can bend your body to do many things.

You have twelve pairs of ribs. They are all joined to a row of bones in your back called your spine.

From the side, your spine looks curved, like the letter S. It helps you to stand up straight.



A tall order

Your bones keep growing until you are in your early 20s.

You cannot change your height—it is decided in your genes and passed on from your parents. But you are about half an inch (one centimeter) shorter in the evening than you are in the morning! This is because the pads of cartilage in your spine get squashed as you walk around all day.

Yes and no bones
The bones of your spine are called vertebrae. The top two vertebrae, the atlas and axis, fit together to allow your head to nod and to move from side to side.

Atlas



Axis



Your nose is not made of bone but of rubbery material called cartilage.

If you look at a skeleton, you will not see a nose bone, only a nose hole.

Radius

Ulna

Fibula

Tibia

Your ankle is a joint. It is made up of bones in the foot and the ends of the leg bones, the tibia and fibula.

Femur

